

<!-- Platform: LinkedIn | Target: 150-300 words | 3-5 paragraphs, 1-2 sentences each Pillar: Career Visibility & Organizational Navigation Status: DRAFT. Not approved. -->

I talked about my management goals in every one-on-one for months. My manager's boss had no idea I wanted to lead.

That is not a story about a bad manager. It is a story about how promotion decisions actually work. Your direct manager is one voice in that conversation. Their boss, their peers, and the broader leadership team are in the room too. If they do not know your goals, they cannot carry your case.

The common advice is to talk to your manager. That advice is right. It is also incomplete. Your manager may have good reasons not to push you toward management right now. They need their team covered. Moving a strong individual contributor creates a gap they have to fill.

Two conversations I have seen change everything: one with the skip-level boss, and one with a senior leader who asked "where do you see yourself going?" Both times, the answer was honest and direct. Both times, the person asking turned out to have a say in what happened next.

If your career goals are only in your manager's head, how much of your advancement is actually in your control?

#leadership #careergrowth #engineeringmanagement #techleadership